Marketing · Agentic adoption, change management, governance and responsible AI

The AI leadership agenda for Marketing: From AI adoption to AI execution

Adoption is no longer the differentiator — scaling is. This is where leaders are focused:

82%

of leaders expect to use AI and agents to meet the demand for more workforce capacity

99%

of organizations have challenges in scaling and operationalizing AI

81%

of organizations lack the talent and organizational readiness to capitalize on AI's transformational potential

The barrier is no longer the technology — it is scale, talent, and readiness

2x

Organizational factors — culture, manager support, talent practices — account for more than twice the reported AI impact of individual factors

Source: Microsoft Work Trend Index

The real challenge isn't the technology

What we see most often

- ❌ Isolated pilots that do not scale
- ❌ Governance as a gatekeeper, not accelerator
- ❌ Delegate AI entirely to IT — no business ownership
- ❌ No accountability for outcomes

What leading organizations do differently

- ✅ Adoption tied to business outcomes
- ✅ Governance that makes it safe to move fast
- ✅ Business + IT = better together
- ✅ Change management from day one

Three shifts that define AI-enabled marketing

PEOPLE

Content producers → Brand strategists

- → Less time producing assets
- → More time on strategy & creativity
- → Roles evolve — they don't disappear

PROCESS

Campaign calendars → Always-on engagement

- → Campaign bursts → always-on workflows
- → Real-time performance signals
- → Agent-assisted content supply chain

BRAND & TRUST

Manual review → Proactive brand safety

- → Spot checks → continuous monitoring
- → Human oversight at decision points
- → Proactive brand-risk detection

Don't bolt AI onto broken processes. Redesign the work first.

THREE STRATEGIC VALUE LEVERS

Where agents create value in marketing

Compress time to market

Campaign localisation 30% faster
Concept → launch in days, not weeks

Multiply creative capacity without headcount

Same team producing 2–3×
the content across markets

Shift from mass to 1:1 personalisation

Personalisation at scale
Asset production: weeks → hours

**The question isn't whether AI will transform marketing.
It's whether you'll lead that transformation — or react to it.**

Value realization is the differentiator

Access to AI is no longer the advantage — what you do with it is

Intelligence is commoditizing

Foundation models, agents and intelligence layers are available to every organization — including every competitor you have. Having AI is no longer a source of advantage.

Application is the differentiator

Advantage comes from applying AI to real marketing workflows — grounded in your enterprise data, embedded in your processes, and genuinely adopted by your people.

Value realization is the moat

The organizations that pull ahead convert capability into measured outcomes at scale — and can prove it. That discipline compounds. Access does not.

If intelligence is becoming a commodity, value realization becomes the moat.

NOT ALL AI DEPLOYMENTS ARE THE SAME — AND THEY SHOULDN'T BE GOVERNED THE SAME WAY

From vision to action: choosing where to start

Different starting points

Some organisations begin with employee productivity. Others start with customer engagement or core process automation. There's no single right answer.

Different risk profiles

An AI assistant drafting copy carries different risk than an agent publishing customer-facing content at scale. Your governance must reflect this difference.

Different ownership models

Some patterns are IT-led. Others are business-led. The most transformative require genuine partnership between business and technology leadership.

THESE ARE DESIGN CHOICES, NOT STAGES. MOST ORGANIZATIONS RUN 2–3 SIMULTANEOUSLY.

Six ways organizations are deploying agents

ASSIST

AI augments people; human stays in the loop

Employee AI Enablement

Make every person more capable

Business Expert Empowerment

Scale subject matter expert judgment

EXECUTE

Agents take action inside your workflows

Workplace & IT Services

Run internal services with AI

Core Business Processes

Embed agents in the value chain

TRANSFORM

Agents create what wasn't possible before

External Engagement

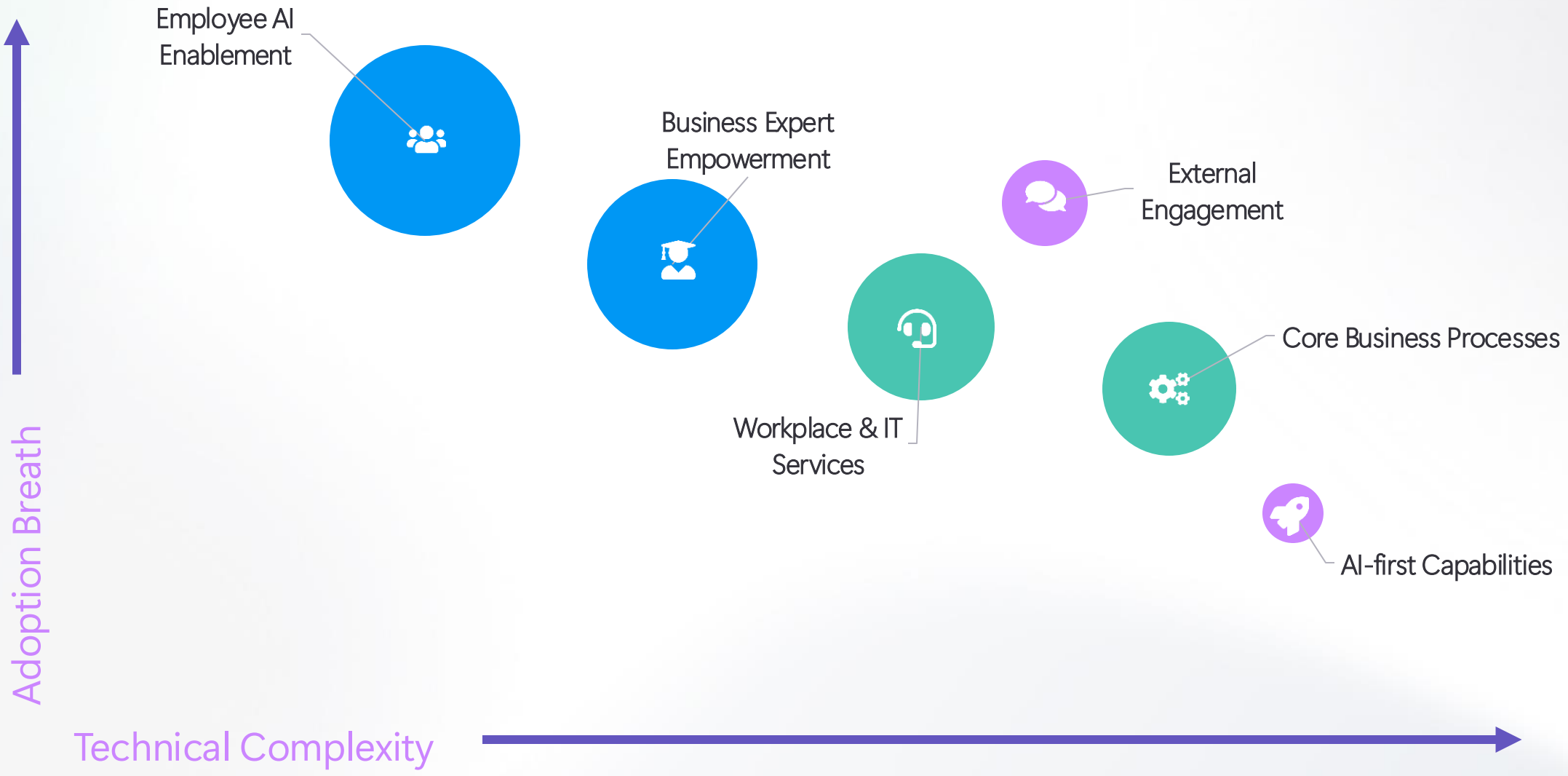
Serve customers and partners

AI-First Capabilities

Build what wasn’t possible before

START WHERE YOU ARE ALREADY STRONG — TECHNICAL DEPTH OR CHANGE CAPABILITY — THEN BUILD THE OTHER. THIS IS NOT A BOTTOM-LEFT TO TOP-RIGHT JOURNEY.

Ease of adoption vs Technical complexity



Pattern 1 of 6

Employee AI Enablement

Make every marketer more capable with AI

The most common starting point. Every team member gets AI assistance for everyday tasks — analysis, communication, data queries.

IN MARKETING

- Campaign copy, briefs, and content drafting
- Audience and campaign data summarisation
- Report generation, formatting, and distribution
- Meeting preparation, follow-up, and action tracking

THE LEADERSHIP CHALLENGE

This isn't a technology challenge — it's a behaviour change challenge. Deployment is easy. Getting thousands of marketers to actually change how they work every day is hard. Measure adoption, not licences.

CASE STUDY

dentsu

Advertising & Marketing · Global

15–30 min

saved per person, per day

Microsoft 365 Copilot rolled out across the global creative agency. Behavior change, not technology, is the challenge.

Source: Microsoft Customer Stories

Pattern 2 of 6

Business Expert Empowerment

Scale your best people's judgement across the organisation

Your most experienced people are bottlenecks. Expert agents capture their knowledge and make it available organisation-wide, on demand.

IN MARKETING

- Brand and creative guidance at scale
- Consumer-insight advisors for every brand team
- Market and competitive intelligence on demand
- Brand-guideline and claims knowledge agents

THE LEADERSHIP CHALLENGE

The expert must stay engaged. If they disengage, the agent becomes stale, loses accuracy, and erodes trust. You need a model where experts curate and validate — not a one-time knowledge dump.

CASE STUDY

The Estée Lauder Companies

Beauty & Consumer Goods · Global

Weeks → minutes

to gather consumer insights

ConsumerIQ, built on Copilot Studio and Azure OpenAI, connects decades of insight so any marketer can query trends in natural language and get strategic recommendations on demand.

Source: Microsoft Customer Stories

Pattern 3 of 6

Workplace services

Things that run the business that cost you money — HR, IT, facilities, marketing operations

Transform internal service delivery. Employees get instant, accurate self-service for routine enquiries and transactions.

IN MARKETING

- Marketing-ops service desk — brand, asset, and access requests
- HR and benefits enquiries routed through AI first
- IT helpdesk and provisioning automation
- Onboarding workflows and new hire support

THE LEADERSHIP CHALLENGE

Service quality must match or exceed what people get today, or adoption will fail. Start with the highest-volume, lowest-complexity enquiries. Escalation to humans must be seamless and fast.

CASE STUDY

Kantar

Marketing Data and Insights · Global

60 countries

Served by employee self-service agent

Kantar built a Copilot Studio HR advisory agent — effectively a team of 10 agents — that answers employee policy questions across 60 countries. It readied around 4,000 HR artifacts in just six weeks, scaling consistent guidance far beyond what a central HR team could field.

Source: Microsoft Customer Stories

Pattern 4 of 6

Core Business Processes

Things that run the business that make you money — agents execute steps in your value chain

Agents don't just assist — they execute steps in your value chain. This is where the P&L impact lives, but the risk is also highest.

IN MARKETING

- Automated content adaptation and localisation
- Campaign production and asset management
- Brand-compliance and claims checks
- Media planning and optimisation workflows

THE LEADERSHIP CHALLENGE

Don't bolt AI onto broken processes. Redesign how work flows first, then bring agents into the new design. This pattern demands the highest organisational maturity — governance, controls, and process discipline.

CASE STUDY

Microsoft

Technology · Global

70%

fewer human escalations

Microsoft's own marketing team built a multi-agent web assistant on Copilot Studio, plus an email agent that detects abandoned carts and follows up. Customers who engage are 10× more likely to sign up; 16% more Azure trial starts.

Source: Microsoft Customer Stories

Pattern 5 of 6

External Engagement

Serve customers and partners with AI — where brand reputation is on the line

AI-powered customer experiences that represent your brand. The stakes are higher because every interaction is visible to the outside world.

IN MARKETING

- Personalised customer engagement
- Conversational commerce and product discovery
- Campaign landing experiences and lead capture
- Partner and channel marketing support

THE LEADERSHIP CHALLENGE

Brand risk makes governance critical. Every customer-facing agent must be tested rigorously, monitored continuously, and have clear escalation paths. One bad interaction can become a headline.

CASE STUDY

Tiendas Cuadra

Premium Retail · Mexico

100%

of questions resolved (88%+ quality)

Tiendas Cuadra's always-on virtual assistant, built on Copilot Studio and Dynamics 365 Customer Service, handles product discovery and service for the premium leather-goods retailer. It resolves 100% of questions at 88%-plus quality with a team of just four people overseeing it.

Source: Microsoft Customer Stories

Pattern 6 of 6

AI-First Capabilities

Build entirely new products and services that weren't possible before

The most ambitious pattern. Not augmenting existing processes, but creating entirely new capabilities powered by AI from the ground up.

IN MARKETING

- Generative, personalised campaigns at scale
- Interactive brand experiences on demand
- Real-time creative generation and testing
- New AI-native consumer engagement products

THE LEADERSHIP CHALLENGE

This requires a fundamentally different operating model. New skills, new governance, new ways of measuring value. Sequence this last — build your maturity with patterns 1–5 first.

CASE STUDY

Holland America Line

Travel & Cruise · Global

1:1 at scale

consumer engagements

"Anna" on Copilot Studio, extended by the CMO into an agent-led marketing model. "With AI, we can have one-to-one conversations with guests, at scale... marketing really starts to become a creative powerhouse limited only by our ability to dream." — Kacy Cole, CMO.

Source: Microsoft Customer Stories

Measuring impact: from productivity gains to hard savings

SOFT COST SAVINGS

Measured in productivity hours saved — the most common and accessible metric for evaluating AI-driven process improvements.

- Hours saved per person per week (e.g., ~2 hrs/week)
- FTE capacity freed for higher-value work
- Faster cycle times (content, campaigns, reporting)
- Reduced rework and error correction effort

HARD COST SAVINGS

Direct financial impact — reduced spend, avoided costs, and revenue protection that flows to the P&L.

- Reduced agency and production spend
- Lower cost per asset and per campaign
- Improved media efficiency and ROAS
- Faster proposals; more wins

AvePoint

Marketing teams cut message development and content production time by up to 66%; storyboard development fell from two hours to 30 minutes.

66%

Source: Microsoft Customer Stories

Making value measurable

Four disciplines that turn anecdote into evidence

01 Baseline before you build

Capture the current cost, cycle time and quality of the process before the agent exists. Without a baseline you can assert improvement — you cannot prove it.

02 Design the measurement in

Decide at design time which signal proves the outcome and where it gets captured. Measurement bolted on after go-live is measurement you will not get.

03 Track leading and lagging indicators

Adoption and usage tell you early whether value is coming. Cycle time, cost and quality tell you later whether it arrived. You need both — one predicts, the other confirms.

04 Run a value cadence

Review outcomes on a fixed rhythm, owned by the marketing leader accountable for the KPI — not by the team that built the agent. Value reviewed once is value lost.

Value assessed after delivery is a story. Value planned before it is evidence.

Finding your constraint

Five maturity pillars — your weakest sets the ceiling

AI Strategy

Coherent vision
or scattered pilots?

Business Strategy

Tied to outcomes
or tech experiment?

Governance & Security

Policies that
enable speed?

Technology & Data

Foundation ready
for scale?

Organisation & Culture

People ready
for change?

SCALE-BREAKER

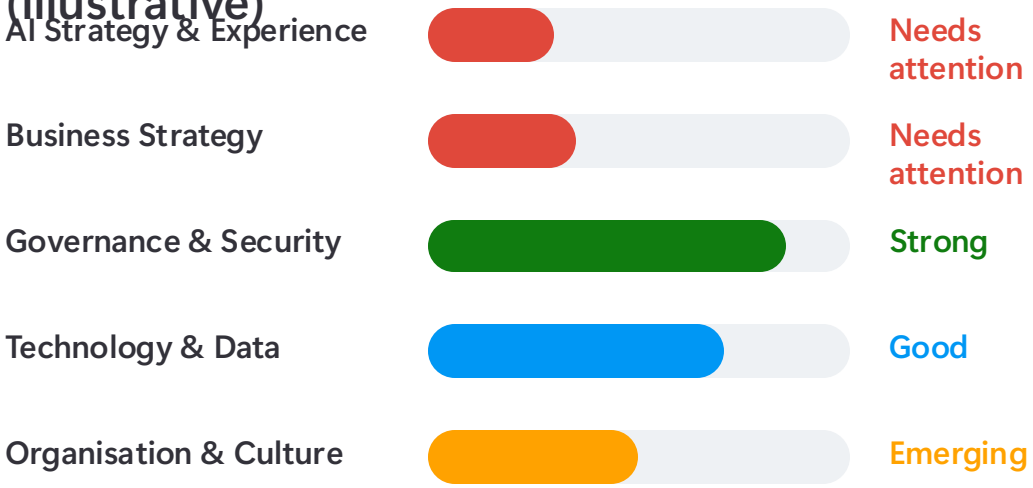
**Find the ONE pillar that will break scale first.
Fix that. Do not boil the ocean.**

Most common in marketing: AI & Business Strategy are misaligned. Governance is often stronger than organizations realize.

Finding your constraint: a marketing example

A typical assessment reveals where you're strong — and where you're stuck

Sample marketing organisation readiness (illustrative)



Your weakest pillar sets the ceiling. Find it, fix it, then scale.

SCALE-BREAKER: AI & Business Strategy

Without strategy, strong governance becomes a blocker:

- No coherent AI vision — pilots are scattered across teams with no connection to each other
- AI not linked to business priorities — projects are chosen bottom-up, not by strategic value
- Governance is mature but slows everything — without clear strategic direction, controls become gatekeeping
- No way to prioritize — every initiative looks equal when there's no strategy to rank them against

What changes for your people

The human side of AI transformation in marketing

Content & Creative	Campaign Managers	Brand & Insights	Performance & Media
Production → Creative direction	Manual execution → Orchestration	Reporting → Real-time strategy	Manual optimisation → Predictive optimisation

WHAT LEADERSHIP NEEDS TO DO

- → Communicate: AI augments, it doesn't replace
- → Invest in critical thinking, not just tool training
- → Coach teams through transition
- → Define where human review stays mandatory
- → Measure adoption, not just deployment

Structured skilling & coaching

A two-pronged approach to building AI readiness

PRONG 1

Tactical exposure

- → Live demos relevant to role
- → "Bring your own process" workshops
- → Technology & UX updates
- → Identify one quick win per person

1–2 hour sessions · Monthly

PRONG 2

Strategic coaching

- → 4–6 week immersive programme
- → Dedicated AI + marketing coaches
- → Real business problems, not hypotheticals
- → Peer learning across functions

4–6 weeks · Ongoing coaching

Tactical exposure creates awareness. Strategic coaching creates capability. You need both.

Decision frameworks for AI in marketing

Who decides what — marketing's role in enterprise AI strategy

THE BUSINESS DECIDES

- Which use cases to pursue
- How to measure success
- Who owns adoption & outcomes
- When to escalate vs. automate
- How to redesign processes

THE ENTERPRISE SETS

- Security & data protection standards
- Responsible AI principles
- Technology platform & integration
- Risk tiers & approval criteria
- Monitoring & compliance

TEST YOUR AI GOVERNANCE

Can a marketing team launch a low-risk use case in under 2 weeks? If not, governance is a gate, not a guardrail.

Balancing Innovation and Governance

Agent Creator/Maker



- How can I **build a conversational agent** that will answer on my behalf?
- How can I build agents that can **drive efficiency and save efforts and costs** for our enterprise?

CISO



- How can I understand all my **data security risks**?
- How can I **discover** all agents and **protect my data** from external threats?
- How can I ensure agents have the right access to data and **prevent data exfiltration**?
- How can I **stay compliant with regulations**?

CIO



- How can I ensure that solutions people are building **follow guidelines?**
- How can I gain **visibility** to what is getting used?
- How can I get **experts to review agents** before they get shared broadly?
- How can I drive **cost efficiency and ROI?**

These are the questions an Agentic CoE and risk-tiered governance exist to answer — the next four slides show how.

A SHARED, ENTERPRISE-WIDE CAPABILITY — NOT A MARKETING TEAM. MARKETING ENGAGES WITH IT TO SHIP AI SAFELY AND AT SPEED.

The Agentic Center of Excellence

THE ENTERPRISE AGENTIC CoE IS...

✓ An org-wide capability, usually sponsored by the CIO, CAIO or Chief Digital Officer

✓ A shared service every function draws on — marketing among them

✓ A connector across marketing, IT, security, legal, data and your agencies

✓ A delivery engine for reusable patterns, prompts and guardrails

✓ A governance backbone — the right decisions by the right people, at the right time

...AND WHAT IT IS NOT

× Not a marketing CoE — marketing is a partner to it, not its owner

× Not a team that builds every agent for you

× Not a control gate that slows campaigns and creative down

× Not a one-off programme — it is a capability that keeps growing

× Not a replacement for your creative, martech or agency teams

Center of Excellence → Center of Acceleration

One CoE serving every function. Marketing brings the use cases, the brand knowledge and the outcomes.

FOUR FUNCTIONS IT PERFORMS ON BEHALF OF EVERY FUNCTION IN THE BUSINESS — MARKETING INCLUDED

What the Agentic CoE actually does

Governs

Guardrails, not gates

Risk-proportionate controls that enable speed. Release gates mean nothing reaches a customer without review.

Release gates · Audit trails · Risk tiering

Enables

Golden paths for makers

Make the right way the easy way. Templates, training and community so marketing teams build well the first time.

Templates · Training · Community · Office hours

Optimizes

Lifecycle management

Agents are products, not projects. Every agent needs health checks, accuracy tracking and an owner.

Monitoring · Evaluation · Drift detection

Scales

Repeatable execution

Turn heroic one-offs into a pipeline: intake → triage → build → deploy → run → improve → retire.

Intake · Patterns · Reuse · Portfolio

THREE WAYS A CoE FAILS

✕ The Gatekeeper

Reviews everything, enables nothing. Teams route around it.

✕ The Ghost

Launched with fanfare. No operating rhythm, no decision authority.

✕ The Perfectionist

Won't let anyone ship until governance is “complete.”

HOW MUCH MARKETING BUILDS FOR ITSELF DEPENDS ON HOW THE ENTERPRISE COE IS SET UP — ASK WHICH MODEL YOU'RE IN

What the CoE's structure means for marketing

Centralized

CONTROL

One central team sets the rules, builds and monitors. Maximum consistency where brand reputation and disclosure are on the line.

MARKETING'S ROLE

Bring prioritised use cases, brand rules and sign-off. The CoE builds and runs the agent for you.

→ Employee AI Enablement
→ External Engagement

Hybrid

BALANCE

The CoE sets standards and supplies expertise; marketing builds within guardrails. A matrix model that enables rather than controls.

MARKETING'S ROLE

Your makers and brand experts build, with CoE patterns and support. Knowledge quality stays yours.

→ Business Expert Empowerment
→ Workplace Services

Federated

SCALE

Marketing owns agent outcomes and delivery. The CoE provides standards, enablement and governs by exception.

MARKETING'S ROLE

You own the full agent lifecycle and staff for it. The CoE sets architecture and responsible AI standards.

→ Core Business Processes
→ AI-First Capabilities

Find out which model your organisation runs before you plan.

It determines how fast marketing can move, what you must staff for, and where you need the CoE in the room.

A CLEAR SPLIT OF RESPONSIBILITIES — THE COE OWNS HOW SCALE WORKS, MARKETING OWNS WHAT GETS BUILT AND WHY

How marketing works with the Agentic CoE

THE ENTERPRISE CoE PROVIDES

- Guardrails, risk tiers and release gates
- The platform, environments and monitoring
- Reusable patterns, templates and prompts
- Agent lifecycle: intake → build → run → improve → retire
- Responsible AI, security and compliance standards
- Telemetry and a common way to measure value

Executive Sponsor · CoE Lead · Platform & Ops · Security & Risk

MARKETING BRINGS

- Prioritised use cases tied to growth and brand outcomes
- Brand voice, claims rules and knowledge quality
- Domain experts who validate what agents say
- Makers who build within the guardrails
- Adoption and behaviour change across the function
- Ownership of the KPIs the agents are meant to move

Business Owner (the CMO) · Brand & domain experts · Makers · Adoption leads

The CoE owns HOW scale works. Marketing owns WHAT gets built — and WHY it matters.

Engage through the CoE's operating rhythm — intake, prioritisation and review. Don't stand up a shadow marketing CoE.

Risk-tiered governance

Match oversight to risk — don't apply the same rules everywhere

Tier 1

Low Risk

Informational & productivity agents

Meeting summaries, research, email drafting

Light-touch approval

Tier 2

Medium Risk

Workflow agents that take actions

Invoice processing, customer service

Business owner sign-off

Tier 3

High Risk

Regulated & high-impact domains

Regulatory filings, credit decisions

Executive & board review

Proportionate governance accelerates adoption. Excessive governance kills it.

Responsible AI: what your board will ask

Fairness

Are decisions unbiased?

BOARD QUESTION

How do we know our targeting and personalization aren't unfair or discriminatory?

Transparency

Can we explain outcomes?

BOARD QUESTION

If a regulator asks how a decision was made, can we show them?

Accountability

Who owns failures?

BOARD QUESTION

If AI-generated content is off-brand or makes a false claim, who is accountable?

Privacy

Is data protected?

BOARD QUESTION

What happens if an agent misuses customer or consumer data?

Get started

https://aka.ms/RAI/ImpactAssessment/Guide

https://aka.ms/RAITransparencyReport

Responsible AI in practice

Three scenarios marketing leaders must prepare for

Targeting bias

Personalisation unfairly excludes a group

CONTROLS NEEDED

Fairness testing in pipeline
Outcome analysis
Clear retrain/withdraw process

REGULATORY EXPOSURE

Consumer protection, ad standards

Brand-safety / false claim

AI-generated content is off-brand or inaccurate

CONTROLS NEEDED

Mandatory human review
Audit trail: AI vs human content
Named accountability

REGULATORY EXPOSURE

Advertising standards

Data over-access

Agent has access beyond what its function requires

CONTROLS NEEDED

Least privilege principle
Regular access audits
Breach process pre-defined

REGULATORY EXPOSURE

Data protection, customer trust

Five decisions every CMO needs to make

1. **Where do we start?**
   2–3 high-value, lower-risk use cases
2. **Who owns this?**
   Senior sponsor — not just IT
3. **What governance?**
   Risk tiers, not one-size-fits-all
4. **How will we invest?**
   Operating model + change management
5. **How do we measure?**
   Efficiency, quality, adoption, risk

What this actually takes

The four questions leaders ask before committing

How long before we see anything?

First agents in production within 90 days. Once guardrails exist, a low-risk use case should launch in under two weeks — if it cannot, your governance is a gate, not a guardrail.

How many people do we need?

Start with three people and a weekly rhythm, not an org chart. Every initiative needs a named business owner — a person, not a team — with the CoE lead, platform and ops, and security and risk in the room.

What if we have no CoE yet?

Start the rhythm, not the organization. Three people, a weekly standup and one intake route will do. Formalize the structure once you have agents in production worth governing.

What do we budget for?

Licenses are the smallest line. Budget for enablement and coaching, the CoE roles, monitoring and platform, and change management — the costs that decide whether the licenses ever get used.

You do not need a bigger model. You need a better operating model.

Your first 90 days

From pilots to production — a practical starting sequence

Days 0–30
Foundation

- Pick 1–2 patterns that match your priorities
- Name a specific owner — a person, not a team
- Run the maturity diagnostic across all five pillars
- Identify your scale-breaker — the one gap that blocks everything
- Audit what already exists: how many agents, who owns them

Days 30–60
Stand up

- Define minimum guardrails: ownership, release gates, monitoring
- Stand up a CoE rhythm — even if it is three people and a standup
- Deliver 1–2 agents to production with monitoring from day one
- Create one shared intake route for new requests
- Start weekly health checks on everything in production

Days 60–90
Scale

- Treat agents as production services, not experiments
- Measure outcomes — not just usage and adoption
- Run your first leadership scorecard on a monthly cadence
- Review whether your scale-breaker has actually moved
- Decide what scales next: which pattern, which team, what investment

Pick your pattern. Name your owner. Find your scale-breaker. Start Monday.

Further resources

aka.ms/AgentReadiness

Assess readiness

Evaluate your organization's readiness across strategy, technology, culture and governance.

Assess readiness

aka.ms/AgenticTransformationPatterns

Download the playbook

The six patterns, maturity model, CoE, and a 90-day play — in one guide.

Download the playbook

aka.ms/AgenticAdoptionGuidance

Explore the Agent hub

Explore more detailed guidance and frameworks to build and scale your Agentic Center of Excellence.

Review further guidance